

STAGE FOURTEEN • PROJECT MANAGEMENT

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Fourteen • Project Management

PURPOSE

Stage Fourteen's individual worksheets are written for solo project planning — build your own timeline, your own risk register, your own stakeholder map. But several of the pitfalls this stage warns against, vague requirements, missed stakeholders, silently absorbed scope changes, are genuinely easier for an outside partner to catch than for the project's own owner to catch alone.

This document adapts seven FIRSTS across all three sections of Stage Fourteen into pair or small-group formats, most built around participants applying the exercise to their own real project while a partner deliberately probes for a specific, named blind spot.

As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements. Complete the individual worksheet first; the group version stress-tests it.

The Seven Adapted Exercises

FIRST R4

Project Requirements Gathered — Interview Relay

TIME: +15 min beyond solo prep

1. Pairs. Partner A describes a real request they've received (a class assignment, a work ask, a favor from a friend) exactly as it was originally phrased.
2. Partner B, playing the role of a probing project manager, asks follow-up questions to uncover the genuine underlying need behind the request.
3. Partner A answers honestly based on what they actually know or suspect the real need to be.
4. Swap roles using Partner B's real request.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Practicing the probing-question skill on a partner's real request is more revealing than reflecting on your own alone — it's easier to spot when someone else's stated request doesn't match their real need than your own.

FIRST R9

Project Risk Register — Risk Speed-Round

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Small groups of 3–4, each referencing their own real project from Session 1.
2. Going around the group, each person names one risk from their own project; the rest of the group has 60 seconds to suggest a possible mitigation, not the risk's owner.
3. The project owner decides whether any suggested mitigation is genuinely worth adding to their own register.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Outside perspective often generates mitigation ideas the project owner wouldn't have thought of alone, since they're less anchored to assumptions about what's fixed or unchangeable about their own project.

FIRST R11

Project Stakeholder Map — Blind Spot Check

TIME: +10 min beyond solo mapping

1. Pairs. Partner A shares their stakeholder map for their real project, without commentary on completeness.
2. Partner B asks: “who's someone with real influence over this project who isn't on your list?”
3. Partner A adds any genuinely missing stakeholder that comes up.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly targets the FIRST's named pitfall — missing higher-influence people who aren't part

of day-to-day execution — by having a genuine outside party specifically probe for that blind spot.

FIRST R15

Project Change Request — Change Request Roleplay

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Partner A plays a stakeholder proposing a scope change to Partner B's real project, using a change they can genuinely imagine being requested.
2. Partner B responds in real time: asking about impact, and deciding whether to accept, reject, or negotiate the change, rather than just silently absorbing it.
3. Debrief: did Partner B's in-the-moment response hold the line on formal evaluation, or did it start to slip into silent acceptance?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Silently absorbing scope changes is much easier to catch as a theoretical pitfall than to actually resist in a live, in-the-moment conversation — this exercise tests the real, harder skill.

FIRST R22

Scrum Experience — Ceremony Jigsaw

TIME: +15 min beyond individual research

1. Assign each small group one Scrum ceremony (sprint planning, daily standup, sprint review, retrospective).
2. Each group researches or discusses their assigned ceremony's specific purpose for 5 minutes.
3. Groups present back to the full room: what is this ceremony's purpose, and what's the most common way people misuse or misunderstand it?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Having each group teach one ceremony to the rest of the room produces deeper understanding than everyone individually reading about all four ceremonies alone.

FIRST R25

Project Escalation — Escalation Script Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Each participant drafts a real or plausible escalation message for their own project individually first.
2. In pairs, read your escalation aloud to a partner, who evaluates: is this specific and actionable, or does it read as either an avoidance of the issue or a vague complaint?
3. Revise based on that feedback.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The FIRST's named pitfall, either avoiding escalation or escalating vaguely, is much easier for a listening partner to spot than for the person who wrote it, who's often too close to their own request to notice its vagueness.

FIRST R29

Project Lessons Learned — Lesson Exchange

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Small groups of 3-4. Each person shares one specific, real lesson from a past project, focusing on the concrete, actionable version, not a vague generality.
2. The group collectively rates each lesson: specific and actionable, or still too vague to actually apply next time?
3. Anyone whose lesson gets rated “too vague” revises it live with group input.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly targets the FIRST's named pitfall — lessons written so vague they provide no genuine guidance — by having peers apply that exact specificity test to each other's real answers.